

THRUST & PARRY

- Draft proposal to make Abhishek TMC national working president dropped for now on Mamata's orders
- Mamata removes security cover for a dozen Abhishek loyalists; one of his loyalists from Alipurduar arrested
- Abhishek announces stern action against party hooligans who use force to rig polls, a first for the TMC
- He introduces one-person-one-post formula in TMC, going against Mamata's line of awarding loyalists with multiple posts
- Wants to give the TMC young brigade more powers, but the old guard is Mamata's comfort zone. Tussle on same lines in state bureaucracy

TMC, so no one is even asking who helped PK prepare the list. "About 30 per cent of PK's recommendations were scrapped, but the leadership accepted the rest as Abhishek's recommendations," says a source, who also added that PK may be on his way out.

"Initially, there was a vertical split—the old-timers versus the younger lot. Now, the split is beyond age and demography, it's a power game between the two top players," says social scientist and professor emeritus at Presidency University, Prasanta Ray. On February 8, TMC secretary-general Partha Chatterjee took a dig at the nephew, commenting that "Mamata has no family", that the state's people are her family,

PULLING STRINGS

Though Abhishek has kept away from the state administrative headquarters Nabanna, the buzz is he has eyes and ears there. The junior bureaucrats are reportedly close to him, but the senior lot are with Didi. Sources also say the IPS lobby is under his control and that he has a say in transfers and postings. Recently, differences between the two power centres cropped up over the selection of the Kolkata police commissioner. Mamata got Vineet Goyal even though Abhishek was partial to Gyanwant Singh. Now, after the Diamond Harbour fracas, Mamata is reportedly planning a reshuffle of IPS officers to get her men in place.

According to one minister, even the appointments of their personal assistants (PAs) was happening via Abhishek's office. The lateral entry appointments of professionals as special secretaries in 30 departments has raised the same fears. A similar arrangement is being planned for the districts to oversee the performance of district magistrates. Governor Jagdeep Dhankhar has flagged the issue. The buzz is that Abhishek has a team, allegedly sourced from Kishor's I-PAC, to keep track of activities, especially the fund management of various departments. The secretary of technical education allegedly took flak because of adverse reports from the team.

Sources say Mamata has now realised the need to "draw a *lakshman rekha*" for everyone in the party. She has reportedly conveyed to party vice-president Subrata Bakshi to inform the district presidents that henceforth only the chairperson's picture (meaning hers) will be used in all publicity material. Pictures of Mamata, with Abhishek alongside, had become a regular sight of late. The directive is apparently to impress upon party leaders/ voters that "there is a single line of control and that is of the chairperson".

THE REFORMER

The TMC is often linked to its rabble-rousing politics, with even Mamata nurturing her streetfighter image. This has extended to the party, which is fraught with allegations of hooliganism and 'cut-money' (corruption). Abhishek, after his elevation, had cautioned them against using "strong-arm tactics" in the polls. He is also keen to bring in reforms such as the 'one-man, one-post' rule.

The young MP has proved that he can handle his own crises. When investigating agencies came knocking at his door, alleging the involvement of his wife in a money laundering case, Abhishek did not try to hide behind the party or Didi but dared the agencies to make public the evidence against his family. His open challenges to BJP leaders like Union home minister Amit Shah also left a big impact on young liberals looking to take on the BJP's aggressive Hindutva push.

The 34-year-old MP has been grooming himself to reach out to first-time voters. From a "kurta-pyjama neta", he has transformed into a young leader who is comfortable in denims and tees and loves his Bvlgari and Apple accessories. Abhishek is articulate and speaks English, Hindi and Bengali well, so he's quite in sync with the educated *bhadralok*, who see more of themselves in him than his aunt. The question now is whether he has overplayed his hand, and whether he can retrieve the situation in the TMC. If he does, this could be a new beginning for him. ■